

Day 5 — *Yajña*: The Ecological Cycle (Gītā 3.10–14)

Module: Indic Ecology · **Band:** Middle · **Time:** 45 min

Learning objective

Students read Bhagavad Gītā 3.10–14 in translation, identify the four-stage circulation (action → sacrifice → rain → food → beings → action), and articulate why “give back” is *built in*, not optional.

Materials

- Printed handout: BG 3.10–14 in IAST with translation, one per student
- Coloured markers (or four colours of sticky notes) — for diagramming the cycle
- A4 paper, one per pair, for the cycle-diagram

Vocabulary

- *yajña* (IAST: yajña; lit. “offering, sacrifice”) — a reciprocal ritual or action of giving. In an ecological reading, every act that gives something back to the system from which we drew.
- *karma* (IAST: karma; lit. “action, work”) — any deliberate action.
- *parjanya* (IAST: parjanya; lit. “rain, rain-cloud”) — rain treated as a being / process in the cycle.
- *anna* (IAST: anna; lit. “food”) — food, sustenance.
- *bhūta* (IAST: bhūta) — being, living creature. (Not the same use as in *pañcabhūta*, where it means element.)

Lesson flow

Warm-up (5 min)

- Daily prompt on the board: “*Who in nature gave you something today? Did you give anything back?*” Two students share.
- Bridge: “*Today’s text gives you a 3,000-year-old answer to that question — and the answer is: giving back is not extra. It’s the cycle.*”

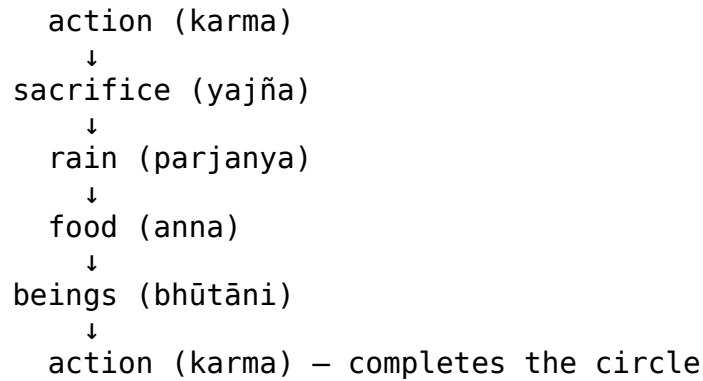
Core (20 min)

1. **Read BG 3.14 first** (the line every student should walk out remembering):

“*annād bhavanti bhūtāni parjanyaḥ anna-sambhavaḥ / yajñād bhavati parjanyaḥ karma-samudbhavaḥ //*”

“Beings come from food. Food comes from rain. Rain comes from sacrifice. Sacrifice comes from action.” — Bhagavad Gītā 3.14

2. **Diagram the cycle on the board.** Draw four nodes in a circle, with arrows:



3. **Read BG 3.10–13 as context** (handout). Key ideas:

- The act of creating beings included the act of *yajña* — they were created *together*.
- The being who eats food without offering it first “eats theft.”
- Those who eat the leftovers of *yajña* are freed of fault.

4. **The ecological re-reading.** The classical reading is ritual: *yajña* meant a fire offering with specific Vedic formulae. But the structure of the verse is more general:

- Action puts something *out* (work, energy, attention).
- That something has to be *given* (to a god, to a guest, to the field, to the river) — not just consumed.
- The system responds (rain comes; food grows; beings live).
- And the beings act, closing the loop.

In modern ecological language: every act of consumption must be balanced by an act of contribution, or the system runs down. Take more than you give → drought, depletion, climate change, soil exhaustion.

5. **Where this differs from “be sustainable.”** The Gītā does not say *be a little less wasteful*. It says: *whatever you take, give back deliberately, or the cycle breaks*. The verse is structural, not moralistic.

Activity (15 min) — Cycle Diagrams for Real Things

- Pairs pick one everyday consumption and draw the full *yajña* cycle for it:
 - **Option A:** A glass of water from the tap.
 - **Option B:** A plate of rice and dal.
 - **Option C:** A 5-minute scroll on a phone.
- They draw four nodes:
 1. *karma* — the action that started this.
 2. *yajña* — what was given (or should be given) to produce this thing.
 3. *parjanya* — the natural process that sustains it (rain, sun, soil, electrical grid).
 4. *anna* — the thing actually consumed.
- For each, they answer: “At which point in the cycle do you, the consumer, give back?”

- Examples to seed:
 - Water: someone has to maintain the source, the pipe, the treatment plant. Most consumers do nothing.
 - Rice: someone grew it; someone harvested it; the soil sustained it. The consumer's "yajña" is paying a fair price + not wasting food.
 - Phone-scroll: the algorithm consumed your attention. What did you give back? (Mostly nothing — that's a real problem.)

Wrap-up (5 min)

- **Mid-module check (formative quiz, 10 min if time allows; otherwise homework).** See quizzes/formative.md Part B.
- One-sentence exit ticket: "*One thing I consumed yesterday for which I gave nothing back: _____. One small giving back I will do this week: _____.*"

Student-facing content

The *yajña* cycle.

"Beings come from food. Food comes from rain. Rain comes from sacrifice. Sacrifice comes from action." — Bhagavad Gītā 3.14

The cycle has four stages:

1. **Karma** — deliberate action.
2. **Yajña** — giving something back from that action.
3. **Parjanya** — the natural processes (rain, sun, soil) that respond.
4. **Anna** — the food / sustenance that returns.

...which feeds **bhūtāni** — beings — who do *karma* again. The circle closes.

The Gītā's claim is that the cycle is *built into how reality works*. Take more than you give, and the cycle breaks. Climate change, soil exhaustion, water tables falling — these are descriptions of broken cycles.

Homework

- Make your own *yajña* diagram for one thing you consume regularly that we did *not* do today (e.g. school uniform, electricity for fan, a packaged snack). Identify the point where you, the consumer, currently give nothing back — and propose one realistic *yajña*.

Differentiation

- **One tier up:** Read BG 3.10–14 alongside one paragraph from a modern ecological-economics source on "externalities" (you can use a Wikipedia summary). Where do the two frameworks describe the same thing in different words? Where do they differ?
- **One tier down:** Memorise just BG 3.14 in translation: "Beings come from food. Food comes from rain. Rain comes from sacrifice. Sacrifice comes from action." That's enough for now.

Teacher notes

- Some students will read *yajña* as “religious sacrifice” and shut down. Push: the etymology is just *yaj* — “to offer, to honour, to give.” A meal you cook for a parent is *yajña*. Paying taxes that fund a sewage plant is *yajña*. Sharing food at a festival is *yajña*. The ritual fire-offering is one form, not the only form.
- Avoid teaching this as “the Gītā is about ecology.” It’s not — it’s primarily about *karma-yoga* (the discipline of action). But the cosmological premise embedded in 3.10–14 happens to be ecological in form. We’re reading one strand, not claiming the whole text.
- Watch out for the “and that’s why everything ancient was right” overswing. The verse is a useful frame; it does not, by itself, tell you how to fix sewage.

Citation(s) used in this lesson

- **Bhagavad Gītā 3.14** — quoted in IAST with translation. Text per standard editions; verse cluster 3.10–14 is uncontroversial across recensions.
- Verse context (3.10–13) summarised in the handout, not separately quoted here.
- See `sources.md`.